

1450–1624

CUSTOM-MADE ARMOUR

While medieval knights wore surcoats over mail or armour, their Renaissance counterparts wanted to show off the splendour of their full swordproof plate. Each suit was unique – reflected in the cost – and increasingly decorated with gilding, inlay, or battle scenes. As the armour fitted perfectly, the substantial weight (about 25 kg/55 lb) was evenly distributed. The knight could move freely and mount and dismount his horse without help – once his servants had undertaken the lengthy task of putting the suit on. The use of full plate armour waned as the 16th century wore on, and handguns replaced swords as the weapon of choice.

Together with the sallet helmet, the bevor (neck piece) offers full head protection

Vulnerable join covered with besagaw (round armpit shield)

Sections buckled together

Full suit of armour Made for Sir Thomas Sackville by the Royal Workshop at Greenwich, this steel, leather, gold, and copper alloy suit, c.1590, weighs a hefty 36.7 kg (81 lb) with its plackart.

Complete protection A knight in full armour did not need to carry a shield. Mail under the plate or sewn into joins covered potentially vulnerable points.

Close helmet with visor

Paned and puffed sleeves

Feathered cap

Striped hose

Colours may have distinguished one company from another

Swiss mercenary Highly skilled fighters were greatly in demand as paid infantry troops. Swiss soldiers, like this one in 1530, set fashion trends with their bright, colour-coordinated doublet and hose slashed into exaggerated shapes.

Detachable plackart gives extra protection

Gold decoration

Broadsword

Complete head and neck cover

Sabatons end at tip of toe unlike 15th-century pointed ones

Made to measure This 16th-century suit of armour was made for Henry VIII when he was past his youthful slimmness. Armour was custom made for a snug fit, so it was extremely expensive.